

HISTORIES OF MUSIC IN ANGOLA

(research of the House of Culture and Social Assistance Lode Apara)

THE HISTORY, THE INSTRUMENTS AND THE INFLUENCE OF ANGOLAN MUSIC IN LATIN AMERICA AND THE CARIBBEAN

Geraldo André da Silva

ABSTRACT

This article aims to demonstrate a bit of the history of music of Angolan origin, positioning itself through the Production of the Culture and Press Sector of the Embassy of Angola, based on an article by the Angolan musician and researcher, Mário Rui Silva, published in the Austral Magazine (TAAG's Inflight Magazine) no. 13, 15, 16 and 18.

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Angolan music is beginning to occupy its space. After asserting itself within our borders, it now timidly begins the conquest of the international audience. But if we want to talk about music in Angola, we must make an incursion into our musical past and even try to dive into the roots of our history. We know that in the distant past there were migrations of the Bantu group in Africa, from north to south, which, upon reaching the region where Angola is located today, pushed the Khoisan and Vatwa peoples, who spoke a language characterized by clicks, further south. When Diogo Cão arrived at the mouth of the Zayli River in 1482, the powerful Kingdom of Kongo, of the Kikongo language, already existed.

What could have been an exchange of friendly relations degenerated into the greatest injustice in all of history: slavery. This quickly became a source of income that exhausted the Kikongo group's region of its best children. Later, the Portuguese expanded south, reaching the bar of the Kwanza in 1560, driven by the ambition to reach the much-talked-about silver mines of Kambambe. Although music was already being written in Europe at that time, we are unaware of any sheet music written by the priests who came in the caravels, with the cross in one hand and the sword in the other.

In 1568/9, the Jagas penetrated the Kongo. They were expelled after violent fighting. A part settles in the region of Kasanji, near Mbaka, and another heads south. We do not know what the degree of linguistic contribution of the Jagas was to the Kimbundu language, nor the degree of musical influence on the Mbaka culture, which is the bastion of that language.

After the arrival of Paulo Dias Novais in Angola and the founding of Luanda, the port of this city became a transit point for slaves to America (who took an entire musical culture with them), just as Mbinda in the Kongo had been. At this time, ethnic movements were already found with more or less defined borders, in a geographical space delimited by diverse linguistic zones.

In 1641, the Dutch arrived in Angola. Their occupation for seven years gave rise to, among others, the Van-Dúnem and Vieira Dias families, who would become notable in the field of music and beyond.

In the paintings of Cavazzi from the 17th century, we can already find musical instruments, such as the dikanza, ngoma, marimba, kisanji, and clochas (double-bell), traditional instruments that are built by the musicians themselves and that we will find among the peoples of our region. We can divide these instruments into:

IDIOPHONES:

- They are instruments that sound by themselves through percussion.
- Saxi (katxakatxa), commonly called maraca, made of maboque.
- After it is dry, small holes are made and dry seeds are placed inside.
- Today, for convenience, beads are already used.
- Bavugu, a common instrument of the Kung group.
- Three greased gourds, in a set based on the play of compressed and decompressed air, plucked by one hand in one of the holes, while the other hole is covered and uncovered, in a back-and-forth movement against one of the thighs of the leg.

MEMBRANOPHONES

- Percussion instruments.
- Ngoma (batuque or tam-tam).
- In bygone times it served to send messages.
- There are various models that vary according to the region.
- Mpwita, a friction drum, apparently originating from the Kongo.
- Inside it has a wooden stick with one of the ends solidly attached to the center of the membrane.
- The wet right hand serves to rub and the left hand puts pressure on the drum skin, depending on the rhythm one wants to mark.

AEROPHONES

- They are very rarely spoken of instruments.
- There is knowledge of the Mpungu, a type of horn of Kikongo origin; of the vandumbu, a soft wood horn covered by a twining of fibers, from the Ambwela group, in southwestern Angola; and the Njembo-erose, consisting of an antelope horn with a globular beeswax resonator, an instrument limited to the area of the Himba shepherds (ovahimba), of the Herrero group, in southwestern Angola.

CHORDOPHONES

- Struck string instruments.
- This is the case of the Hungu, also called Mbulumbumba, heavily used by the Khoisan people.
- It is built from a bow, which possibly previously served to shoot arrows, with a gourd tied to it.
- The left hand, supporting the set, practices a back-and-forth movement against the belly.
- The right hand, with a small stick, strikes the string.
- This instrument was taken by slaves to Brazil, where it is called the berimbau and serves to accompany an acrobatic dance called capoeira de Angola.

BOWED STRING INSTRUMENTS

- Kakocha, a type of violin with three strings.

PLUCKED STRING INSTRUMENTS

- The tchihumba, consisting of five mateba strings, or more, connected to the stems and a resonance box.
- It is held with one hand and played with the thumbs.

LAMELLOPHONES (INSTRUMENTOS DE LÂMINAS)

- Marimba.
- Of Asian cultural influences, it is an instrument that can be found near the Kalandula falls and also in the Lunda region.
- Kissanji.
- It is an instrument with a fluid sound, used to keep company on long walks, or as background music when an elder tells stories around the fire in the moonlight.
- On the soundboard, lamellae (which can be bamboo or metal) are fixed, attached to a bridge.
- The instrument is held with both hands and played with the thumb of each.
- Some great players even use their index fingers.
- It is also called Mbwetete when it is made of bamboo.

All these instruments are used depending on moments adapted to needs, such as birth, puberty, marriage, hunting, chants for rain, liturgical rituals, funerals, sweeping of ashes, spirituals, etc. Among the many rhythms that accompany them, we can mention the kabetula, kilaphanga, semba (rebita), and makinu.

With slavery, cultures were exported to the Americas (North and South), which later gave rise to other cultures, including musical ones. In the case of the meeting of Portugal with Angola and Brazil, it is known today that from the maritime voyages of the 17th century an exchange was established between the peoples of the Iberian Peninsula and the Amerindians, which gave rise to the fandango, a popular Spanish dance that appeared around 1769. Everything leads us to believe that the Spaniards learned a dance from the Amerindians in their colonies that gave rise to the fandango in Seville, where there were already influences of oriental musical culture, cultivated by the Moors and gypsies.

The fandango would meet in Lisbon, in the 18th century, with the fofa and lundu dances, coming from Brazil, resulting in the fado which, according to José Ramos Tinhorão, "would synthesize in the 19th century, moving from the tavern to the salons to become a song". It should be noted that the so-called lundu dance in Brazil, which emerged in Bahia in the 18th century, also appears in Lisbon in the late 1770s. This is a dance that is related to the Kaduke of Mbaka (Angola), and which became one of the most popular dances in Luanda under the name masemba (navel bumps, plural of semba), which is characterized by the meeting of bodies, in the navel bump. It is an erotic dance taken by slaves to Brazil and which adapted there to the economic and social framework.

The word lundu comes from kilundu which according to António Asis Júnior means spirit, a being of the invisible world, and Cordeiro da Mata refers to it as a supernatural entity that directs the destinies of man. Its diminutive is Kalundu. Today, in our popular slang we have the expression "está com os calundus" (he is with the calundus), meaning attacked by madness.

In Brazil, the forced encounter between Portuguese and blacks and a part of the Amerindian culture with the cadence rhythm of the Angolan Kaduke/semba gave rise to the samba, a highly controversial term. But Liceu Vieira Dias says that "samba is Kaduke. Semba and Masemba are the same thing. Semba is singular. The prefix ma, in Masemba, is plural. Samba is directly linked to masemba and semba. Samba is not, as the Brazilians thought, a fact of folklore to which they attached this name. Samba is the infinitive of Kusamba (to pray). And it is natural, as I once said, contrary to what Câmara Cascudo affirms, that there in the large plantations where the plantation owners were isolated in their mansions with their family, that at night, in the yards, the slaves would gather to ask the gods to return to their homeland, to their land. Then they used the term Samba, they confused it with Samba, which was to pray, to implore and ask God, through an ethno-choreographic and musical manifestation, as was common in all primitive peoples. This was considered not from a religious point of view by the plantation owners but from a recreational point of view. Hence the fact that they connected a religious manifestation with a festive manifestation, with a festive act". This is what happened".

With the "coming of the exiled soldiers without women, an encounter was created between the peoples and a consequent increase in mestizos and shod blacks, who swelled the ranks of a nascent petit bourgeoisie". The effects left by Napoleon's invasion of the Iberian Peninsula would catalyze the process of cultural symbiosis, which was already operating in the music made by the people who concentrated around the city of Luanda. But that is another story, more recent, which we hope to develop in an upcoming chronicle.

II. THE PEOPLE, THE ENVIRONMENT AND THE TIME - OUTSTANDING FIGURES OF THE ERA (1875/1935)

We propose in this chapter, to take our readers to the universe of suburban music; its genesis, its most representative figures (poets, painters, intellectuals, musicians, officials or simple inhabitants of popular neighborhoods or the periphery), all committed to defending Angolan culture in general, and music in particular. But talking about men implies talking about their environment: Luanda, the catalyst of cultural and political life, of yesterday and today.

When approaching this theme it is essential to refer to two concepts, in our view essential, that we would like to define to strip them of all the connotations to which they were subjected over time and, above all, during the colonial era. These are "traditional music" and "folklore". Traditional music can be considered as linked to a very distant past, transmitted orally from generation to generation, linked to habits and customs (praxis). This music influenced the popular music that manifested itself around the city of Luanda.

To classify this type of manifestation, the word folklore emerges. It is a word of English origin (1846) product of the union of folk (people) and lore (science). Folk-lore, science of a people, science of traditions, of customs of the popular art of a country. By extension (1877), folklore: set of these traditions, songs, popular legends of national, provincial folklore.

Over time, the word folklore took on a different concept from the one that gave rise to it, and that is how we will find it in "large dictionaries: "picturesque aspect but without importance, or without profound meaning" and as a familiar locution the expression: "it's folklore, it's not important". In Africa, it was the second meaning of the word that we received. From here, we can deduce that the word Folklore must have served to classify certain manifestations considered unimportant by Europeans.

But let's return to the history of music in Angola. "Luanda, was still at this time a small city, inhabited as we saw, essentially by merchants and officials, occupying themselves with business, the center of all attention".

In the 19th century, Augusto Tadeu Bastos (1872/1936) was born in Benguela, a multifaceted personality in the field of arts, letters, and sciences. He was a musical composer and painter, journalist and novelist, lecturer and linguist, ethnographer and historian, scholar of astronomy and mathematics. Among the various songs of Angolan motif that he composed and performed on the piano, the waltz "As Furnas do Lobito" stood out. To date, we do not know where the sheet music is located.

In 1875, a composition emerges to us, which is titled *Madya Kandimba* (Maria Bunny). It is one of the first pieces of the *Masemba* choir collected by Óscar Ribas that he presents to us in his book *Misoso III* (1964). The piece tells us the story of a European in love with his African maid. The wife, upon learning of this romance, pistol in hand, sets out looking for the maid, who flees by boat. Due to its melodic and poetic structure, we are led to believe that *Madya Kandimba* is already a defined product in terms of cultural symbiosis. Other more recent pieces have the same structure, which leads us to believe that the genesis of suburban music is already prior to 1875.

1884 is the date attributed to the composition *Kinjangu* (big machete). We do not know if it came already composed/created from the areas around Ngulungu Alto or if it was created in Luanda by those who came from this region. After listening to some musicians from the 40s, we learned that *Kinjangu* was known for his barbarous acts committed against the people from whom he himself was descended, in part. In this composition it is said that he (*Kinjangu*) should be careful, because when the time came (independence), those who were not from the house would have somewhere to go/flee, but he, being from the house, would have to settle accounts with his fellow countrymen. This idea is translated into the stanza where the wild guineafowl (*hanga*) is mentioned, referring to the occupant, the Portuguese, and the domestic chicken (*sanji*) to make reference to the son of the land. It is worth highlighting the message given through the reference to the slave who aborts, and to the mistress who gives birth in order to highlight the injustices in the context of the social strata caused by the forced encounter between the son of the land and the occupant, whose objective was money, more important than life.

The word *Kinjangu*, in this composition, designates the name of a person of Italian origin (*Quinjango*), but coincides with the word "kinjangu" which in Kimbundu translates to machete wielder, the one who possesses a machete or works with it. Machete in Kimbundu is *Njangu*, a word belonging to a class whose plural is *jinjangu* (machetes). The word in the singular adding the prefix *ki-* (*ki-njangu*) can also be interpreted as the big machete, if we consider the prefix *ki-* as an augmentative. Faced with all these indications, we are perplexed regarding the semantic value to be attributed to this word in the thematic context of the piece itself. Knowing minimally the people from where this composition originates, their sarcastic and humorous spirit, we may have a tendency to opt for the translation of the word *Kinjangu* as "big machete".

When Angola appears in 1885 with its borders drawn at the Berlin Conference, the effects of the return of musical cultures exported by slaves (Brazil and Portugal) were already being felt in Luanda, especially since the two compositions: *Madya Kandimba*, from 1875 and *Kinjangu*, from 1884 were already found with defined musical scales: the major and its relative minor.

In the last decade of the 19th century, Alfredo Troni (1845/1904), a famous Portuguese lawyer highly interested in Angolan affairs, forgot his law practice and became one of the high frequenters of Masemba. He was so popular that he was even spoken of in one of the songs of his time. "Tolony, kina kyambote Trony, dances well ilumba, yala ku muxinda the girls, are in line."

In the first quarter of the 20th century, the Angolan artistic environment would benefit from the experience lived by intellectuals of lineage, based on traditional or popular culture. Cordeiro da Matta (1857/1894) with the edition in 1891 of a book of proverbs (jisabu) and riddles (jinongo-nongo), which we will find in some popular songs, thus certifies to us the origin of the inspirations of popular music that became known years later.

The old Luís Gomes Sambo (1874-1946), "a prominent figure of the noble families of Cabinda", a man of great knowledge in herbs and in the musical field, "herbalist and naturalist", dedicated himself to classical music. He was the author of compositions for bands and winds that he directed and with which he paraded in the streets of Luanda in festive moments, such as the carnival. Prestigious in the Angolan and Portuguese social circles of Angola, he paraded his band around the country. He did not exhibit himself with fewer than fifteen figures. He resided in Kaxitu, but traveled often to Luanda, Benguela and Katumbela. The band played typical "fanfare" music, in bandstands in Luanda and Kaxitu, before 1943. There are no traces found of his sheet music. His grandsons, some of them contemporary musicians, know some of his melodies.

António de Assis Júnior (1877/1960) "was the first president of the African National League in 1930". He published a beautiful Kimbundu-Portuguese dictionary, also with popular proverbs.

Voto Neves "was a former treasurer of the Luanda City Hall". He played the guitar and sang African and Portuguese songs. He knew and read music, even gave lessons, and already wove considerations about music, "explained the similarity, at least euphonic and melodic, of Brazilian music with ours, saying that the baião itself has African origins. "Liceu" (1919/1994), years later, defending the same thesis.

The old Rodrigues Ndongo, "is one of the precursors of Angolan popular music". He was already a great Bahian guitar player in 1935. He had an ensemble formed by the old Borja (father of Xodó), José da Conceição, who played the violin, a finance official, (father of Noémio da Conceição), accompanied on guitar by Cabedo de Lencastre, who also already sang in Kimbundu (madya kandimba, for example). José da Conceição dos Santos (father of the late José Cordeiro, who belonged to Ngola Ritmos), and Aleixo Palma, grandfather of the late singer Belita Palma.

Filipe Amado (karola) (1894/1968), "a graphics worker at the National Press of Angola", a man of the dikanza according to some, also gave a few touches on the accordion. "A popular figure of the masemba and commanded the semba circles with the elegance and authority of a good master of ceremonies.

Abel Fontes Pereira, another top accordionist, father of a great composer: Fontinhas and his brother, Oliveira F. Pereira, founder of the theater group Ngongo.

António Palma, "originating from Kabiri, was the father of Belita Palma, a singer who distinguished herself in the 60s. He was a Justice official and also plucked string instruments. He passed away very old, free, somewhere in Lubangu, where he ended up in exile.

Nga Firmino (1091/1995), originating from Malanje and a bricklayer by profession, was an accordion player and knowledgeable of a series of pieces of Luandan suburban music. Many of them were part of the repertoire sung by the generation of the 40s.

A little later, prominent figures would appear. This was the case of Manuel dos Passos, a great companion of "Liceu" (musician and composer of the 40s) considered by Domingos Van-Dúnem "as a man of depth of thoughts, of a unique culture. He was born within kimbandismo. He was a master.

Xico Machado is no longer of the same opinion. Although he recognizes the value of Manuel dos Passos, he says "Álvaro Caldas for me was the greatest because he was exactly embedded in the environment where he lived, whereas the other wasn't, Passo became an official.

Jaime de Sousa Araújo tries to clarify us a little more and tells us that "Manuel dos Passos mastered Kimbundu and knew cultural details of spiritual life, in filial conviviality with a great spiritist lady, Xika Aniceto (1872/1959), a mestiza, resident of the working-class neighborhood, next to the water tank. This important lady to whom Óscar Ribas also made reference, gathered numerous people in her house and dealt with mental culture, like the "macumbas" of Brazil. She was the "library" of Manuel Passos" who was raised by her. In the book *Izomba*, Óscar Ribas tells us that "Francisca Aniceto was truly a renowned kimbanda among the native Luandan masses.

Manuel Passos had "some quality in the social space of salons and native dance houses. Even evolving in the same environment he had a multifaceted and differentiated behavior, due to the education he had received. Manuel dos Passos' presence did not clash whether in the salons of the African National League, of the selected bourgeoisie, or in the salons of "kilaphanga" or "masemba". He stood out.

"Caldas was different, due to the lack of certain habits and experience in environments different from the Bairro Operário, Tanque de água, Caribala, etc.(...) However, he revealed himself to be an intelligent and popular figure in the dance circles of the suburban neighborhoods. The biggest difference was dictated by the economic conditions of both. "Álvaro Caldas did not feel well in the dances of the League or the Association of the Natives of Angola, which obliged certain precepts of posture and presentation... He dedicated himself more to the popular music of "Batuque" or poor and carnival salons, such as the Satire of dispute between "Fineza", "Coração" and "Cidrália"; this band, headquartered in the Bairro da Ingombota, where he was born. (...) Sometimes one would look for Caldas in the "Kilapanga" salon, located at the Water Tank (Bairro Operário), where he sang and danced.

Another important figure of Luandan folklore was Flávio Galiano, a bourgeois of lineage. He recalled the resourcefulness of the "Creole" revelers of Brazil. Athletic, an official of the Bank of Angola, like his brother, high jump champion and 4 X 200 relay runner, Flávio was one of the good defenders of the Sporting Clube de Luanda in the thirties. A brawler, when he had to defend his carnival hosts. Tambourine player of one of the most famous dances of the suburbs "Coração" or "Pincão", he was affable and gentlemanly in the exercise of his banking duties. Flávio knew how to reconcile social behaviors, so as to become an exemplary bank employee; playful during carnival periods and a difficult adversary in fights, some of them fought on the Island of Cabo, where in leisure periods he spent the night lovingly cohabiting.

We could also talk about Horácio Van-Dúnm, about Adão Correia, but to date it has not been possible for us to collect necessary data. Other men, many of them unknown to the new generations, distinguished themselves in this combat, some sometimes even unconsciously, for the affirmation and revaluation of music in Angola. They had in common the will to live and absorbed different influences coming from outside. In fact, they were rhythms and dances of Angola that, taken by slaves out of the country, returned to the land modified, influencing the young Angolans who identified with them. This is the case of the Tango, samba, blues, jazz...

In Argentina, in 1864, there was already talk of the Tango. Written in the Bantu language: tangu, in Kimbundu, means "branch". It comes from the milonga rhythm, but we are not documented to state whether there was a rhythm with that same name in Angola. Upon hearing the milonga rhythm (in Argentina) we recognize a relationship with the kaduke/semba (in Angola). The word milonga is the plural of mulonga, which in Cordeiro da Matta's dictionary means: crime, mystery, offense, figurative, resentment. In Assis Júnior's dictionary it has the meaning of contentions, issues, demands(...) disagreements.

In Brazil, in 1930, there was already talk of samba (prayer) which comes from the liturgical rituals performed by the slaves.

In North America, the African chants and dances taken by the descendants of the art of the griot (troubadour, storyteller) give rise to the blues. This must have appeared around 1870, after the war of secession and the abolition of slavery. Blues chants, spirituals and ragtime are the elements that are at the origin of jazz. We cannot specify the date of the appearance of all these rhythms in North America. However, we know that between 1880 and 1910 some blacks from Louisiana clung to a set of traditions and developed them according to a new social context, which was theirs.

My desperate search for the roots of the culture that is intrinsic to me, can find its explanation in the words of Jaime de Sousa Araújo when he says: more than half a century later, I know how to evaluate the qualities of these great folklorists, citizens of criticizable bearing in the era of greatest social prejudice and whom scholars and musicologists ignore. Like Manuel dos Passos, Álvaro Caldas, Alfredo Lopes Teixeira, Flávio Galiano, specialists should still pay attention to figures of multifaceted behavior who, after all, deserve the greatest tributes of gratitude, like the popular poets and brothers Amilcar Neves and Eurico, sons of the old Aurélio (voto) Neves, another folklorist of lineage. (...) These precursors of culture compared themselves to great figures of Brazilian music and carnival. They remain ignored.

III. THE GENERATION OF THE 1940s/50s. LUANDA AND ITS MOST OUTSTANDING FIGURES

Luandan musical culture is the fruit of various encounters. Various population groups arrived in Luanda from various regions of Angola, with a preponderance of the Kimbundu, Kikongo and Mbundu groups. These groups brought with them their own cultural universe and as time progressed they adapted to the new realities.

One of them, coming from Mbaka, brought the kaduke, a ritual that was danced outdoors, accompanied by rudimentary musical instruments. In Luanda, in contact with new realities, it became a ballroom dance, where the accordion entered, the men dressed in tuxedos and the women with their beautiful cloths.

"The Portuguese nobles exiled as a consequence of the French invasions of Portugal, arrived in Luanda without their wives and accustomed to a social life strongly influenced by French culture, influenced (...) the natives of the country". On that occasion, associations were founded, where dances were organized. These were based on a type of choreographic movement that is exactly that of the French "cotillon" (...). Some figures of the development of the dance, which was collective, were commanded(...) in French: changer la dame, tourner à droite, tourner à gauche. Moreover, there were many other French expressions attesting to their influence".

Arlindo Barbeitos, remembers having seen/heard in Dondo, when he was a kid, a voice of command initiating this ritual, in an intonation that he still knows how to imitate: un deux trois maintenant ça commence.

This dance, the Kaduke, is characterized by the semba (navel bump, plural masemba): men and women clash. It is an erotic dance, suitable for those who found themselves alone.

In 1921 recreational groups were created and immense compositions were popularized with a content linked to the objective realities of everyday life. The anonymous composers of this time, sometimes based on popular proverbs (we don't know if these proverbs already had a melody at the time), were able to unleash their imagination and add parts of their authorship, some of a sarcastic nature, if not political, and thus leave crystallized in consciences the substrate of a new culture in gestation.

Luanda at this time was already a mixed-race city, under various aspects of daily musical life. The effects of the musical culture exported by the slaves were already being felt in some parts of the planet. The tango, the samba, the blues, jazz and merengue have a great impact on the musicians in Luanda, sensitive to this return of their rhythms and dances. Among them they manifest sympathies for the samba, perhaps because it is closer to a local rhythm and more directly linked to the mixed-race population's culture.

In the mid-30s, names were already evident, such as: Voto Neves, Alfredo Lopes Teixeira, Flávio Galiano, Amílcar and Eurico Neves (popular poets, sons of the old Voto), Luís Gomes Sambo, António Palma, Nga Firmino, Fansony, Filipe Amado (Karola), José Vieira Dias, José de Fontes Pereira, Mestre Geraldo, Horácio Van-Dúnem, Adão Correia, Óscar Ribas, Pwaka, Virosas, Teófilo José da Costa (Cu de Palha), Domingos Benedito de Palma (father of Bélita), Guilherme de Assis, (son of the writer of Terra Morta), the old men Saraiva and Cordeiro, Álvaro Caldas, Manuel dos Passos and many others. All these men, indirectly or directly, belonged to the mosaic of the music of Luanda. They were part of the musical family tree and were the branches of the trunk of a tree whose root plunged into the depths of a distant past, with unknown names. But other branches would be born.

Outstanding Figures of the time The old Rodrigues Ndongo, one of the precursors of Angolan music, had a group formed by the old men Borga (father of Xodó), José da Conceição (Finance official, father of Noémio da Conceição and the late Cordeiro), who played the violin accompanied on guitar, Cabedo de Lencastre, who also sang in Kimbundu (Madya Kandimba, for example) and Aleixo Palma. Chico Machado, who later revealed himself to be a good samba singer, also tells us that at this time there were some Tunas, where the characters were Liceu's father (Vieira Dias) who played the piano, the Martins brothers, from Ambriz, Alfredo Saraiva, Abel Lencastre and others whose names I don't remember". Still according to Chico Machado "Liceu's father often clashed with us, because of our line. He did not support us and Liceu would say: well, it is because of you that we are subjugated. He and his father fought constantly. And the father argued: kids, you have no mileage and you want to teach us the true path. Grow up and show up. He was a nationalist..."

At this time the Turma do Barulho already existed. In the opinion of Gabriel Leitão, "this group must have lasted until 1944, with names such as Beto Pimentel (guitar), Pedrinho seminarian (guitar), Guilherme Cordeiro (guitar), mirumba (tumbas), Xikitu Kwarrata (guitar), Pitorra and Ermelinda".

Liceu, in 1936, already benefited from the conviviality of Manuel dos Passos and Óscar Ribas de Araújo. Young Nino Ndongo, his cousin, at the time 10 years old, when he went to his house with his father's guitar in hand for a few lessons, remembers finding them there.

It was in this musical environment with serenades and parties, still spoken of today and remembered with nostalgia, that the OSMACE brothers (Óscar, Mário and César) disembarked in Luanda, coming from Portugal, where they studied in one of the most respected colleges. The music was going to enter another phase.

The authors would compose not in a spontaneous way, but reflectively beforehand. To achieve certain objectives, Liceu, already influenced by a family of musicians, gained a certain sympathy for Óscar and with him advanced his knowledge on the guitar. With Morais, who had just arrived from Brazil and with whom he also learned a series of "little songs", the Grupo dos Sambah was formed, consisting of Liceu, Óscar Araújo, Antonino Van-Dúnem, Lacerda, Alfredo Saraiva and Chico Machado. Óscar, as Liceu says: "introduced what is called the love for Brazilian music(...) which led us to discover our culture and the value it has".

In a first phase some songs are composed, such as "Mirumba dos Olhos Fundos", "Golpe Profundo", "Luar Indiscreto", "A Divisa Desta Turma", "O Samba e o Mundo", "Oxalá", "Adeus de Despedida", "Arrependimento" and "Adeus". By this time Liceu already had music of a demanding nature. This is the case of "Paulistanas de Cá e de Lá", from 1937, and "Caminhos de Abrolhos", from 1939, which are only known by the members who come to be part of the group (Antonino Van-Dúnem, Lacerda, Saraiva and Morais).

On March 3, 1938, they made a live broadcast to Brazil. The sound technician was Zé Amado, who was at the time head of production for the Radio Club. Chico Machado, who also belonged to the group, tells us that the little girls Gertrudes and Helena Portugal also even sang, and Tia Idalina (knowledgeable of many songs from the era of the recreational associations) was a regular presence and commanded the audience, to the point of having a large cheering squad at the Bota-fogo sports field which, still according to Chico Machado, "was an arm of the Grupo dos Sambah".

In 1940/41, benefiting from the conviviality and information given by Manuel dos Passos and Domingos Van-Dúnem and, as Chico Machado says, with the melodic influences heard at home from his mother and her sister, the famous aunt Guinhas, Liceu was able to recompose the pieces Muxima and Mbiri Mbiri. All this leads Chico Machado to say that it was Liceu who fixed these songs, all of them monochordal and monotonous, derived from various stories to which it was exactly necessary to give another dimension, another life, already thinking of commercializing them. The songs needed to be three minutes long. Normally it was a small verse, always repetitive. It was necessary to fix it, adding several stories and various musics. If Liceu had not intervened, it is possible that these songs would have become known. But one thing is certain, at that time it was him who did it, no one can take that merit away from him.

Years later Liceu, Domingos Van-Dúnem, Nino Ndongo, Aníbal de Melo and Manuel dos Passos began to hum "a few things" from the time of the Grupo dos Sambahs. At a certain point Liceu, conditioned by the time, turns to his colleagues and says: "...well, the problem here is that we cannot enter, in this phase, into such open songs, as we did in the time of the Grupo dos Sambahs, with messages in Portuguese. We have to use our songs. Our traditional music (at that time we sang Brazilian music). We have to use our cultural motifs and therefore we will pass on our traditional music. We took the content, which was empty, it meant absolutely nothing, local problems of a social nature, social politics I don't know what, and we injected messages to wake the guys up and understand that it is time for us to start thinking. And then I took the lyrics, transformed them and the music, which were patchworks, I made some rhapsodies and we went out to the street. (...) Some of these "little songs" had probably already been sung in recreational associations, extinct in 1945, and in the carnivals. The rhythm, because it was installed in the body, manifested itself, passed from parents to children and accompanied various manifestations of everyday life.

At a certain point, some songs began to be repeated on the asphalt, outside the carnival framework. The guitar started to be used to accompany these chants, in Saturday gatherings, around our "plates", where the "mwamba wa sanji", "mwamba wa mbiji", "funji ya xitu" or "funji ya mbiji", were delicacies made by an "older woman" experienced in these culinary matters. The gatherings ended at dawn with a "muzongê" (fish broth with palm oil), irreplaceable for a hangover.

These men and others, well or badly, are inserted in the process of integrating the guitar into the environment. The musical pieces harmonized by Liceu and Nino Ndongo were already in well-defined tempered scales (major or its relative minor), certainly of European/Portuguese influence. Liceu, lulled by his rhythmic research, had already transcribed the Kasukuta rhythm to the guitar, using two chords (Im/V7/II#) of the relative minor scale. By this time the transcription of some rhythms from the field to the city, played on the guitar, already had the form known today.

Fruit of various meetings with Domingos Van-Dúnem and Manuel dos Passos, from the point of view of the analysis of literary themes/texts, and with Liceu and Nino Ndongo, for harmonic coverage of a mixed nature, a musical-cultural-political group would be born. In a meeting between Mário de Araújo, Liceu and Chico Machado, the name for the group was discussed and Chico Machado tells us that "it was Mário who gave the last idea, saying: no, let's put in Latin terms we rhyme at the end, NGOLA RITMOS". According to Domingos Van-Dúnem the group was born in 1947.

These boys, some of them without realizing it, created what would serve as a cultural basis for subsequent generations, like ours, which begins to reflect on its Elders, like something that fades away as the possible informants of that era, which must be wonderful, disappear. Young people looking for themselves, to the point of having launched the cry LET'S DISCOVER ANGOLA, whose echo still rings in the ears of those who were born here and hold on to their land, depending on it like a tree depends on its root to continue growing.

IV. THE LUANDAN SUBURBAN MUSIC FROM ITS ORIGINS TO THE END OF THE 50s The suburban music of Luanda is the fruit of the distant encounter between Europeans and Africans who were forced to approach the city, becoming a reserve of cheap labor. This labor relationship gave rise, years later, to a new type of housing around the European city and to the emergence of the assimilated who learns, by force of circumstances, the Portuguese language, to the detriment of his mother tongue. The songs coming from the suburban belt, in the content of their lyrics, make reference to the social injustices between the two races.

The black man, upon settling around Luanda, dependent on the work provided to the white man, creates recreational associations, where we find the first names of those who served as a connecting link between the culture of the countryside and what would give rise to the new Luandan music. They were singing made, probably, of feelings related to the nostalgia of the past. People from 15 to 30 years old who came to Luanda without a family. The tune of the melody must have been melancholic, with memories of country life where they came from, driven by the need to have to work for the European/foreigner.

These new recently arrived people must have polarized a part of the population of Luanda with the musical scales coming from the countryside. The compositions that must have been created in these new living conditions, establish a break with traditional music, in its thematic, although the melodic line has kept some connecting links, not very evident. But if an "older person", in their singing, has a melodic connection with tradition/past, the present germinates in them new values that end up externalizing, with more evidence, in their children or grandchildren. This generation, which will be eternally anonymous, created over the years the bases of a new musical culture. There are no documents that can certify this statement. Only our imagination can lead us to interpret things this way.

There are several ethnic groups that come to join in a region like Luanda, dragged by slavery and bringing with them their secular/millennial culture. All of them are from the same Bantu family. They come into contact/clash with another culture, the European, where the relations between white/black were of exploitation and expropriation.

There is no exact date that can mark the beginning of Luandan suburban music. It is at the end of the 18th century, beginning of the 19th, that the first social factors begin to emerge that give rise to new protagonists in the musical field. With the generation of the 40s, conditions are naturally created, which give rise, in '47, to the appearance of the famous Ngola Ritmos which, at first, had difficulties being accepted by the European public when it sang in Kimbundu.

Invited to animate a dance, the public, after hearing so much singing in Kimbundu, would say: "Go play there in the museke!". "Liceu", hurt by this type of reaction, reflects and at another dance decides to sing Portuguese songs. When the "common folk" were already in the hall dancing animatedly to the songs of the "holy homeland", our "Liceu", already in agreement with the other members of Ngola Ritmos, gradually inserted the rhythms of the land in Kimbundu. The dancers, in suit and tie, continued to keep the beat in the dance, a little surprised. After all it's not bad at all! And there they gradually accepted the songs in Kimbundu.

The generation of the 40s was the reflection of the rejection of the colonial power to all indigenous cultural manifestations. This generation knew how to establish a connecting link between the countryside and the city, without belittling the culture of its ancestors, so that those who were under the dominance of Portuguese culture felt touched and became sensitive to this cultural movement that was characterized, over time, by transformation and adaptation to the new era.

The generation of the 40s appeared with a batch of songs, most of them of popular origin, which reflected the joys and sorrows of a people subjugated to colonialism and which ran in the mouth of the people. Ngola Ritmos makes them its favorite repertoire, introducing new chords and a mixture of rhythms, creating an acculturated music, in the good sense of the term, where the rhythm, melody, harmony and poetry would outline, in a clearer way, the difference between suburban and urban music.

In 1950 Domingos Van-Dúnem appears at the head of Gexto, with Gabriel Leitão, Higino Aires and Antonino Van-Dúnem (1914/1995). By this time there was already talk of Garda and his group, and Duya with Bento, Maneco and Chinito form the Demónios do Ritmo.

In 1951 Botafogo is founded. It started with sports and recreational activities and lasted only 3 years. In 1953 Guilherme Assis creates the group Cama (Conjunto Artístico de Melodias Angolanas). That same year Botafogo, for reasons beyond its control, paralyzes its activities, which only resume in 1956, then harboring many of the Angolan revolutionaries. It is important to highlight the figure of Quim Jorge who, according to Roldão Ferreira, contributed greatly to the growing appreciation of our culture.

Sebastião Coelho tells us about the first interview, in Benguela, of Ngola Ritmos, held in 1952 and the appearance of the singer Ana Maria Mascarenhas, who revealed herself to be an excellent composer. Some of her songs were recorded on disc, years later, by her sister Conchinha de Mascaranhas. Jaime de Sousa Araújo tells us "that this year Ngola Ritmos, was already making a splash with Timpanas in the city of Luanda".

By this time, through Ngola Ritmos, many popular songs had already become famous and few were those who knew the stories linked to their origin and original form. In this same year Zeka Saraiva, who at the time worked at Rádio Club, says he recorded a show of Ngola Ritmos at the African National League and in the Bairro Operário, in the backyard of the late Xodó, for a program by Domingos Van-Dúnem, "Domingo Sereno", in Kimbundu, sponsored by the Nocal beer factory.

In 1957 José Oliveira de Fontes Pereira creates the Escola Semba and we also have the Kisweya (tyrant, beast) with Barceló de Carvalho (Bonga) as a great harmonica player, Carlos David André, Tizinho, João, Nando Kajibota, Lamartine and several dancers.

In 1958 the group Ngola Dimuka is formed, directed by Beto Guise and at the end of that year, beginning of 59, the Negoleiros do Ritmo appear. In the first formation appeared Almerindo Cruz, Joãozinho Morgado, Carlos Geoveti and Dionísio Rocha.

In 1959 the groups Mulogais do Ritmo, Quimbandas, Mwenyu wa Ngana, Gingas and Ilundo are formed. The Duo Ouro Negro performs at the Restauração and "Kurikutéia" becomes the opening song of their shows. That year José Oliveira de Fontes Pereira, with the Escola de Semba, parades in the carnival with the song "Sanji Yami" and the Duo Ouro Negro gives its first show in Lisbon.

In the early 60s the theatrical ballet group Kisanji do Ritmo already enjoyed a certain fame, supported by the Association of the Natives of Angola, ANANGOLA. Kyavulanga tells us that "Muxima wa tete, Xikela and Kaminina, were songs that belonged to the group's repertoire, abusively used and reproduced by other groups, even on record" and he also speaks to us of the Jograis de Angola, consisting of Eleutério Sanches, Moisés Menezes, Couto Cabral and Guerra e Silva. Also created in that era were other cultural associations, such as the Theater Club of Angola and the Friends of the Theater Club.

Roldão Ferreira says that "by this time the theatrical ballet group Fogo Negro is formed, which took theater to the streets on carnival days and Garda already played piano and guitar. The Maianga square and the Armazéns do Lima area, were areas where this cultural movement was noted".

In 1961 the "4th of February" takes place and a day later S. José Lopes, director of PIDE, orders the doors of the Botafogo group closed. On October 4 of that year, Oliveira Fontes Pereira, who was an important element in the Theatrical Ballet group Fogo Negro, manages to create the Ngongo Theater Group. The first was called Alambamento, written by Fontes himself and was never presented to the public because, according to Roldão Ferreira, Fontes Pereira was suspended from Ngongo in the same year of its formation and replaced by Quim Jorge, from the Technical Department, who proved to be an excellent composer. Another important figure of Ngongo was the expert guitar player Catarino Barber (1937/1985).

Another name that lulled the generation of our parents was Eleutério Sanches, poet, musician, painter, a concrete case of mixed-race music in Luanda and author of unforgettable melodies. The famous song known as "Luanda", which the Duo Ouro Negro came to record years later, is a composition that excels in its simplicity.

By this time there was already talk of the voice of Lilly Tchiumba (1937/1989), whom Ferrando Silva considers an "artist-combatant, perhaps a pioneer in the fight for the rights of the female artist". There also appeared the beautiful compositions by Rui Mingas, Ixi Yami and Mwimbu wa Sabalu, this one with a poem by Mário de Andrade.

The decade of the 60s is fascinating. In it we will find the effects, in our musicians, of the return of the intrinsic elements of Angolan culture, which traveled to various parts of the world. Anything done in Angola cannot fail to have similarities with what has already been done in other parts of the world. It will be difficult to connect a music to the Angola of tomorrow that would easily be identified as Angolan, just as today we can connect the Tango, the Kachimbu and the Milonga to Argentina, the Samba and the Bossa Nova to Brazil, the Rumba and the Bolero to Cuba, the Merengue to the Dominican Republic, the Beguine to Guadeloupe, the Bamba and the Plena to Puerto Rico, the Cumbia and the Curulao to Colombia, the Mento and the Reggae to Jamaica, the Blues and Jazz to the United States.

Nevertheless, any self-respecting Angolan cannot fail to react to melodies eternalized by Ngola Ritmos, to the voice of Lourdes Van-Dúnem, of Euclides Fontinhas, of the late Belita Palma, to a guitar solo by Zé Kenu, to a rhythmic marking by Joãozinho da Ngoma, together with Carlitos's guitar, in the rhythm of the Semba, as only he knows how to mark, or to a melody by Elias dya Kimwezu, not to mention the late Artur Nunes, at the time already adored by the elders.

When we listen to the few old recordings of the time, in the voices of some already deceased, we cannot avoid tears and memories of a past time, and we realize a work that did not have due continuity, due to certain mistakes made that no one today wants to assume. Well, "the fault lies with the conjuncture".

Brasília, October 05, 1999.

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